TEJASHWI LEADS THE CHARGE

IN BIHAR'S FERVID POLITICAL ATMOSPHERE, THE RJD CHIEF'S YOUTH-CENTRIC MESSAGE BATTLES A BJP RELYING ON PM MODI'S APPEAL AND A MUCH DIMINISHED NITISH KUMAR

BY AMITABH SRIVASTAVA

"OUR APPROACH IS ONE OF *SANTUSHTIKARAN* (SATISFACTION), theirs (the Congress-led opposition) is *tushtikaran* (appeasement)...." In a 30-minute address replete with rhetoric and promises of a better tomorrow, at Munger on April 26, Prime Minister Narendra Modi did not pull his punches. From Bihar's "dark ages" under Lalu Prasad and his Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) to the Congress's "ominous gaze" on the common man's property (via the much hyped 'inheritance tax'), the BJP's campaigner-in-chief whipped up enough bogeys to make a strong pitch for the NDA.

Like the past few times, the saffron party's campaign in Bihar this time, too, leans heavily on the appeal of PM Modi. Chief Minister Nitish Kumar has held public meetings and road shows, but his rhetoric is limited to critiquing the RJD—his ally in government till a few months back—and, like Modi, in recalling memories of Lalu's jungle raj. However, much water has flowed under the Gandhi Setu since then and making the narrative stick is an onerous task.

In fact, it is Lalu's son and RJD chief Tejashwi Yadav who seems to have a more secure grip on the poll narrative now. By April 29, the 34-year-old leader had addressed an impressive 75 public



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